

Optimizing Your Debian 13 Desktop -

 teejeetech.com/2025/08/14/debian_13_tips

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Debian 13 was released last week. This article offers some tips to help you get the most out of your new Debian desktop.



Enable Additional Repository Areas

Debian's package repositories are organised into separate *areas* (or *components*) like main contrib non-free non-free-firmware, etc.

- non-free contains packages whose licences are not FOSS
- contrib contains dependencies of non-free packages

contrib and non-free are not enabled on a Debian system since they contain non-FOSS packages. You can enable the non-free areas to get access to additional packages such as nvidia-drivers, aac-enc, faac, etc

Edit /etc/apt/sources.list as shown below:

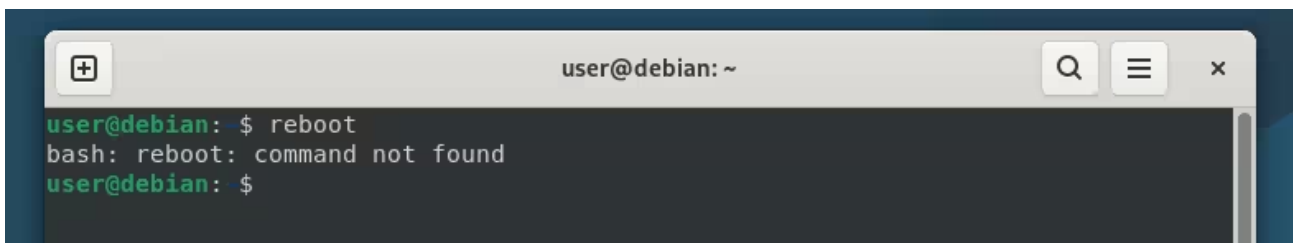
```
deb http://deb.debian.org/debian/ trixie main contrib non-free non-free-firmware
deb http://security.debian.org/ trixie-security main contrib non-free non-free-firmware
deb http://deb.debian.org/debian/ trixie-updates main contrib non-free non-free-
```

```
firmware
deb http://deb.debian.org/debian/ trixie-backports main contrib non-free non-free-
firmware

#deb-src http://deb.debian.org/debian/ trixie main contrib non-free non-free-
firmware
#deb-src http://security.debian.org/ trixie-security main contrib non-free non-
free-firmware
#deb-src http://deb.debian.org/debian/ trixie-updates main contrib non-free non-
free-firmware
#deb-src http://deb.debian.org/debian/ trixie-backports main contrib non-free non-
free-firmware
```

Add sbin folders to your PATH

If you try to reboot your Debian system by typing `reboot` in the terminal you will get the following error:



Error

Debian has a long-standing tradition of separating system administration tools from regular user programs. Regular users don't have `/usr/sbin` in their environment's `PATH` variable. This means that your terminal doesn't know where to find the executable file for the `reboot` command when you type `reboot` in a terminal. You need to type the **full path** to make it work.

```
/usr/sbin/reboot
```

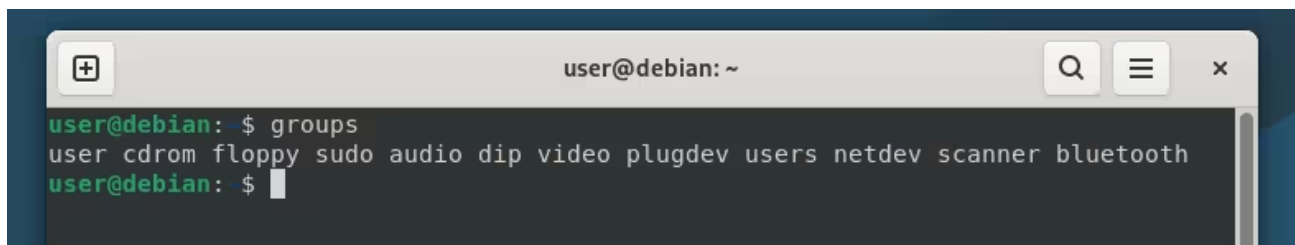
This can be inconvenient when you are the only user on your computer and wish to run administrative tools without jumping through hoops. Add a single line at the end of your `bashrc` file (`~/.bashrc`) to add the `sbin` folders to your `PATH`.

```
export PATH="${PATH}:/usr/local/sbin:/usr/sbin:/sbin"
```

Add yourself to System Groups

Debian adds new users to a limited set of system groups in order to restrict their privileges. This is good for security, but inconvenient when you are the only user on your computer.

You can check the groups you belong to using the `groups` command:



```
user@debian: ~  
user@debian:~$ groups  
user cdrom floppy sudo audio dip video plugdev users netdev scanner bluetooth  
user@debian:~$
```

Default groups

If you are the admin for your computer, you can add yourself to some optional groups to make your life easier.

```
sudo usermod -aG adm,crontab,input,kvm,lpadmin,render,staff $USER
```

What these groups do:

Group	Purpose
adm	Access log files in <code>/var/log</code> and system monitoring tasks without needing <code>sudo</code>
crontab	Running the <code>crontab</code> command to view, create, and edit scheduled jobs
input	Changing some input settings (mouse and keyboard) without needing <code>sudo</code>
kvm	For running VMs using Virt-Manager and KVM
lpadmin	Manage printers and print jobs without needing <code>sudo</code>
render	Give access to a rendering device like graphic cards
staff	Add and modify files in <code>/usr/local</code> without needing <code>sudo</code>
vboxsf	Accessing shared folders from inside the guest OS in VirtualBox VMs
vboxusers	USB passthrough (connecting USB drives to VirtualBox VMs)

Use Cloudflare DNS for quicker web browsing

A DNS server acts like a phone book for the internet. When you type a website address like `google.com` into your browser, your computer doesn't know where to find it. It first sends a request to a DNS server, asking for the website's numerical IP address (e.g., `142.250.191.46`). The DNS server then provides that address, allowing your computer to connect to the correct web server and load the page.

An installation of Debian 13, by default, uses DNS servers of your local ISP which are usually very slow. [Google](#) and [Cloudflare](#) provide public DNS servers that are much faster.


```

18:19:46 teejee teejee-vm ~
→ sudo nala fetch
[sudo] password for teejee:
Fetching Debian mirrors...
  Fastest Mirrors

```

Index	Mirror	Score
1	http://debian.mithril.re/debian/	25 ms
2	http://debian-archive.trafficmanager.net/debian/	32 ms
3	https://mirror.sg.gs/debian/	34 ms
4	https://mirror.djvg.sg/debian/	36 ms
5	http://ftp.es.debian.org/debian/	41 ms
6	http://ftp.cn.debian.org/debian/	44 ms
7	http://ossmirror.mycloud.services/debian/	48 ms
8	https://mirrors.cloudforest.co.th/debian/	48 ms
9	http://ftp.hk.debian.org/debian/	51 ms
10	http://ftp.tw.debian.org/debian/	53 ms
11	https://mirror.nitc.ac.in/debian/	53 ms
12	https://mirror.xtom.com.hk/debian/	59 ms
13	http://opensource.nchc.org.tw/debian/	61 ms
14	https://mirror.twds.com.tw/debian/	68 ms
15	https://debian.uvigo.es/debian/	69 ms
16	https://mirror.xeonbd.com/debian/	69 ms

Score is how many milliseconds it takes to download the Release file

```

Mirrors you want to keep, separated by space or comma (1..16): |

```

Nala - Select Mirrors

Enable Snap and Flatpak

Debian is a stable distribution where the software in each release remains unchanged throughout its 5-year lifespan. Packages do not receive major updates or new features - only bugfixes and security patches.

While this is great for having a stable and reliable system, it is not so great when you want to use the latest and greatest software. That's where Snap and Flatpak come to the rescue.

Run the following commands to add support for Snap and Flatpak packages:

```

# snap
sudo apt install snapd

# flatpak
sudo apt install flatpak
sudo flatpak remote-add --if-not-exists flathub
https://flathub.org/repo/flathub.flatpakrepo

```

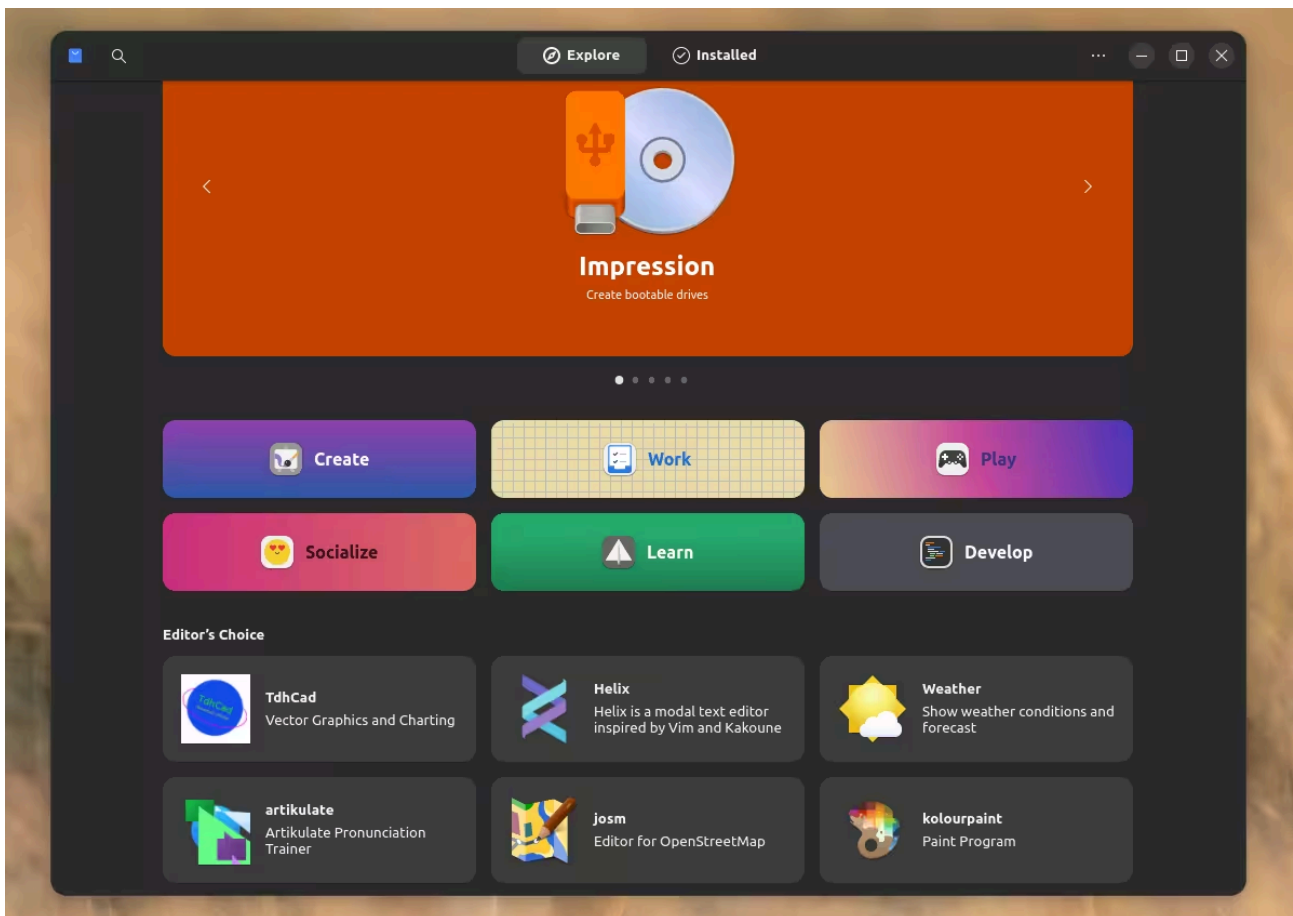
You can search and install software using syntax similar to Apt.

```
sudo snap search mission-center  
sudo snap install mission-center
```

I prefer Snaps over Flatpaks since they take up less disk space. Each snap package is an XZ-compressed archive that is mounted to a loop device and used directly, instead of unpacking the files and wasting disk space.

Install GNOME Software Centre

Linux lacks a good FOSS GUI for browsing and installing Flatpak and Snap packages (not considering paid apps like [Appy](#) which can do all this and more). *GNOME Software* is the closest option available.



GNOME Software

Run the following commands to install the Snap and Flatpak plugins for *GNOME software*.

```
sudo apt install gnome-software  
sudo apt install gnome-software-plugin-flatpak  
sudo apt install gnome-software-plugin-snap
```

The first time you open *GNOME Software*, you'll need to wait a minute for it to download package information and app icons. Once the initial download is complete, your experience will be much smoother.

GNOME Software installs software updates in offline mode when you shutdown your computer. This is similar to how updates work on Windows and can be extremely annoying as a Linux user.



Offline Updates

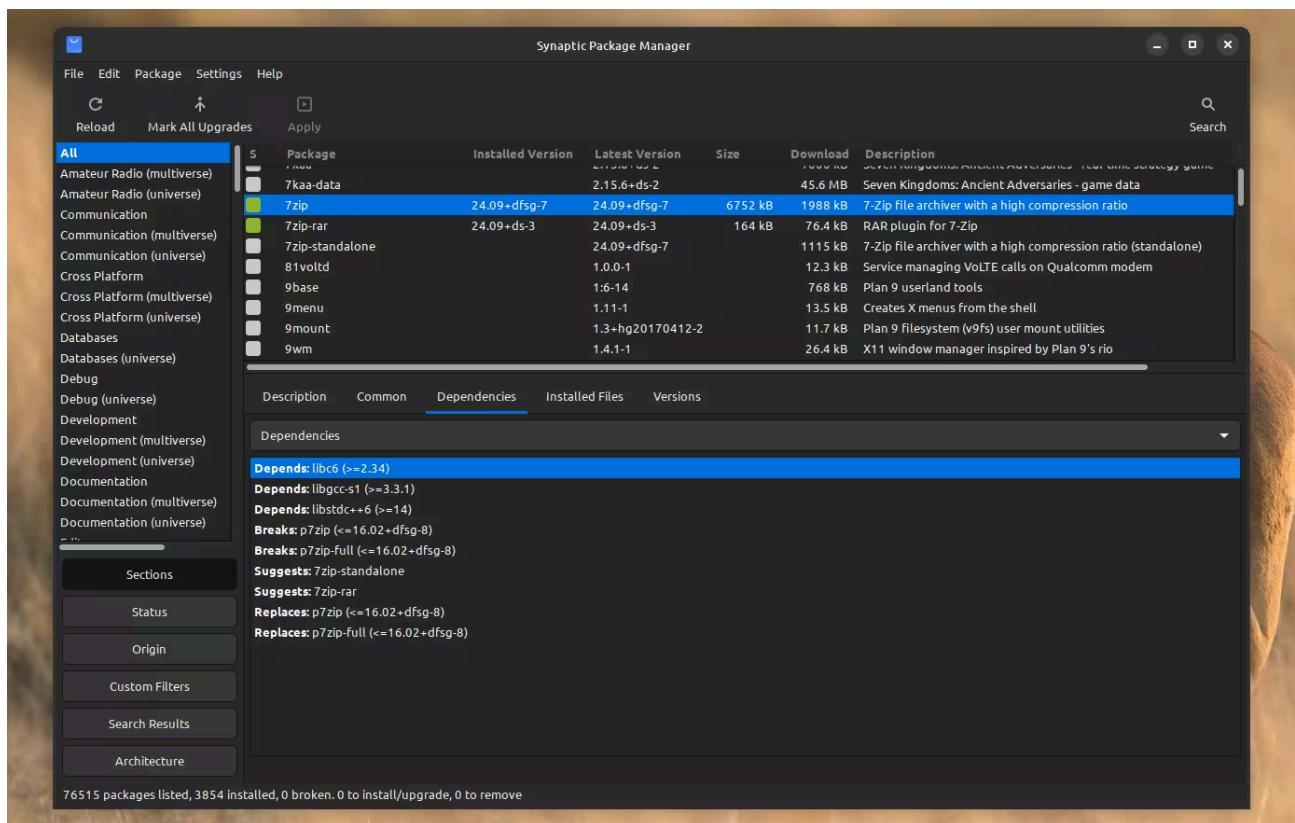
Disable offline updates with the following command:

```
dconf load -f / <<EOM
[org/gnome/software]
allow-updates=false
EOM
```

This will also hide the *Updates* tab in *GNOME Software*'s main window.

Use Synaptic for Apt packages

Synaptic is a classic GUI tool for managing Apt packages. It helps you browse through the entire catalog of packages in your Debian or Ubuntu repository.



Synaptic Package Manager

Install *Synaptic* with the following command.

```
sudo apt install synaptic
```

Add a shortcut to your desktop for the next time that you want to install or remove packages.

See also

- [Ubuntu 26.04.1 Updates](#)
- [Flash USB v26.08](#)
- [DEB Installer v26.08](#)
- [ChronShield v26.08](#)
- [LIA v26.08 \(Aug 2026\)](#)